

Ministerial Entitlement Abroad

What Union ministers get on their trips abroad and the process of clearance

Kanti Singh

MoS for heavy industries

Number of trips: 6

Km travelled: 54,756

OFFICIAL EXPENSES:

Not provided

Ram Vilas Paswan

Minister for chemicals, fertilisers and steel

Number of trips: 5

Km travelled: 58,640

OFFICIAL EXPENSES*:

Rs 25.3 lakh

**For fertiliser ministry only*

Murli Deora

Minister for petroleum and natural gas

Number of trips: 5

Km travelled: 41,242

OFFICIAL EXPENSES:

Rs 12.6 lakh

B.K. Handique

MoS for chemicals, fertilisers and parliamentary affairs

Number of trips: 5

Km travelled: 51,819

OFFICIAL EXPENSES*:

Rs 69,000

**Borne by parl. affairs ministry*

Akhilesh Prasad Singh

MoS for agriculture, consumer affairs, food

Number of trips: 5

Km travelled: 79,663

OFFICIAL EXPENSES:

Rs 30.5 lakh

THE RULE BOOK

For every visit by a Cabinet minister, whether official or private, initial clearance is required from the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA). After clearance, the file is sent to the prime minister for final approval. Only visits by the President, the vice-president and the prime minister require no sanction.

THE TAB

In case of ministerial visits, the bills are paid by the Indian missions in the countries concerned and then settled through book transfer with the ministry concerned.

ENTITLEMENTS

Ministers are entitled to five-star hotel junior or executive suites in the range of \$2,000-4,000 (Rs 80,000-1,60,000) a day. In cities like New York, Paris and London, their entitlement is a normal suite during the peak season, but the wow factor often leads ministers to go in for presidential suites which can cost upward of \$6,000 (Rs 2,40,000) a night. One former external affairs minister would insist on staying in a boutique hotel in Paris and the mission there had to justify that it was the only hotel

available although the tab was close to €2,000 (Rs 1,14,000) a night. A Union minister has a fetish for a luxury suite in Dorchester Hotel in London which costs £1,700 (Rs 1,31,000), plus the cost of a butler and tips, which add another £200 (Rs 15,500).

Ministers are entitled to a dearness allowance of \$75 (Rs 3,000) a day. For transport, cars are hired by the local mission or provided by the host government for the entire delegation. This can cost about \$40 (Rs 1,600) an hour for a Mercedes E-Class and \$100 (Rs 4,000) an hour for the S-Class. Meals are provided by the mission or the local hosts.

To justify the luxurious stays, the reason given is that the minister would be meeting foreign dignitaries. Since there is no upper ceiling, the suites often can cost a bomb. For instance, the two one-bedroom residential suites on the 51st floor of the Four Seasons New York cost

\$15,000 (Rs 6,00,000) a night. In Dubai, the Burj Al Arab Hotel offers a Royal Suite at \$10,400 (Rs 4,16,000) a night and a slightly smaller presidential suite at \$9,200 (Rs 3,68,000). Even though the host governments very often offer their state guest houses, our ministers prefer hotels.

Ministers are supposed to fly Air India only.

But often they use other carriers on the grounds that A-I flights are not available or don't directly connect the destinations.

ministers visited Thailand and 14 ministers went to Malaysia at least once, either on official or on personal visits. Interestingly, junior ministers (read MoS), who more often fret about not getting enough to do, managed to show up on foreign shores. As many as 33 of the total 40 made 311 trips in total and spent 1,388 days abroad. Surprisingly, there are seven among them who did not

step out of the country at all. They include M.H. Ambarish, MoS for information and broadcasting; J.P.N. Yadav, MoS for water resources; M.V. Rajasekharan, MoS for planning; Manik Rao Gavit, MoS for home; Subbulakshmi Jagadeesan, MoS for social justice; Taslimuddin, MoS for civil supplies and V. Radhika Selvi, MoS for home.

Here's another interesting detail. Italy,

Purandeswari is one of the ministers whose personal trips outnumber official ones. She has been outside India for almost 2 months which include only 5 official days.

D. Purandeswari, MoS for human resource development

